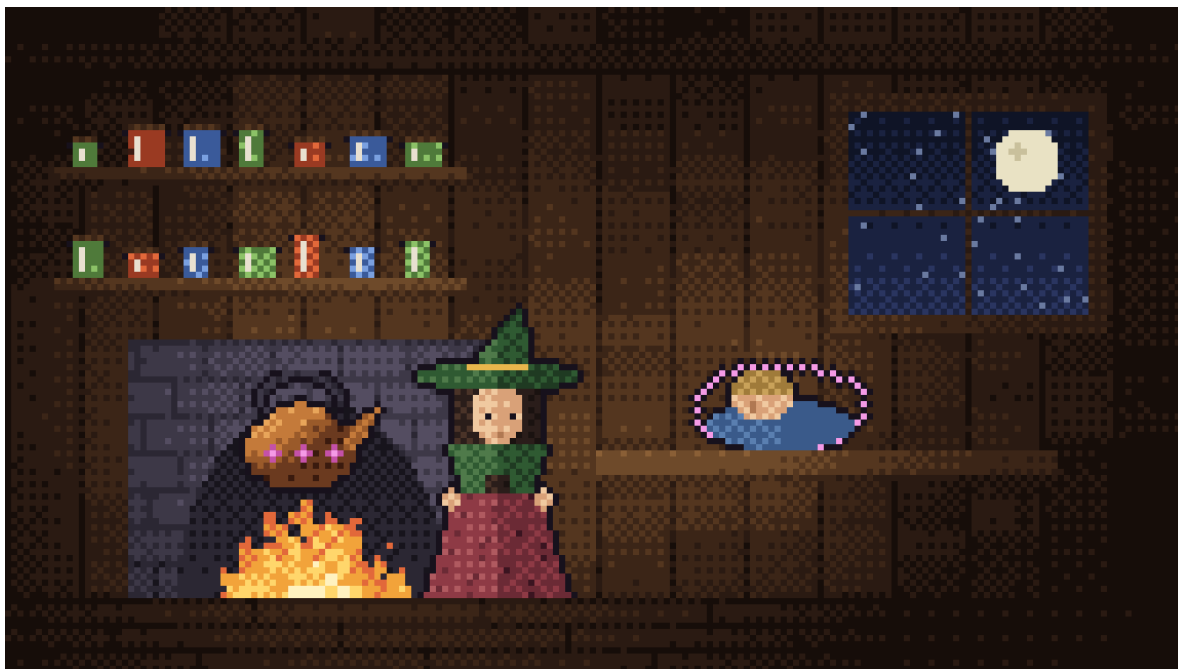


Alchemist's Arsenal

Game design document



Brew the bombs · Arm the heroes · Break the curse

Intended systems

Genre

Target age of players

Intended ESRB / PEGI rating

Projected ship date

Engine

Windows PC (Windows 10 / 11, 64-bit)

Shop management × auto-battler, 2D pixel art

10+

E10+ (Fantasy Violence) / PEGI 7

18 December 2026

Unity 6 (2D, Universal Render Pipeline)

Nuno Gonçalves

Version 2.1 · 23 September 2026

Outline

Game story summary

The night before Tam leaves for the Coven's school on the Peak, Tam and their older sister **Nell Ashgrove** fight. Nell reaches for the little kettle-charm her grandmother taught her, the one that calms a room, and says it crooked because she is angry. Tam lays their head on the table and does not wake. At dawn **Sister Veil**, the Coven's envoy, is at the door: a sleep-curse, she says, that only the Coven's **Matriarch** can lift, with a cure whose ingredients lie along five roads.

So Nell does the one thing she can. She opens her potion shop at the forest's edge and arms the heroes who will walk the road for her, and every flask she brews becomes a bomb in somebody else's hands. Each region pushed back — the **Whispering Woods**, **Cinder Peaks**, **Frostbite Caverns**, **Venom Swamp** and the **Coven's Peak** — brings home a clue: the trees whisper her grandmother's name, a scorched page describes a ward "for when they come for the child", children sleep in the ice with Coven thread round their wrists.

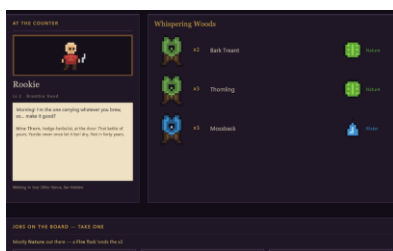
At the summit the Matriarch's mask breaks, and under it is **Grandmother Ysolde**, who went up the mountain to stop the Coven taking children and was made into their Mother instead. Nell's crooked words were never a curse: they set off the ward Ysolde hid in the kettle, which put Tam to sleep where the Coven could not reach them — and the "cure" is the key that breaks it. "*You didn't break my charm, Nell. You finished it.*" The ward lifts only when the one who spoke it lets the anger go. Nell pours the cure into the fire, Tam wakes, and when Veil comes back for the child she finds every hero Nell ever armed standing in the doorway.

Description of gameflow (what is the player's experience)

Alchemist's Arsenal fuses a *Papa's Pizzeria*-style shop rush with a *Jacksmith*-style auto-battler. In most shop games the customer walks away and the story ends; here, the player follows their product out of the door, watches it succeed or fail in battle, and comes back the next morning to do better. Every in-game day has three phases:

Phase	What the player does	Mood
Morning — the shop	Every hero going out comes to the counter and takes one of three jobs. Then race a real-time clock across five benches — malt the grain, grind the leaves, stir the cauldron, bottle the brew — working every hero's flask side by side.	Frantic hands
Afternoon — the road	The heroes carry those exact flasks into one of five elemental regions and fight waves of monsters, and each region's guardian, on their own, choosing for themselves what to throw at whom. The player watches, and can speed up or pause.	Calm mind
Evening — home	Read the report and the pay, buy upgrades, hire and level heroes, pick tomorrow's party and road, and watch whatever part of the story the day earned. Sleeping saves the game.	Quiet

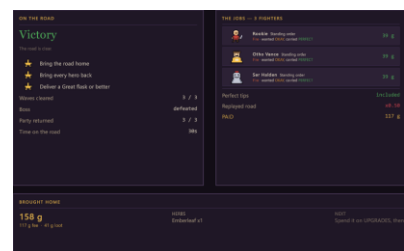
The through-line is **quality**. Every flask is scored from 0 to 100 as it is brewed, and in the afternoon that score becomes damage, ammunition, elemental effectiveness and pay. There is no abstract score screen: a sloppy flask visibly fights worse, and the player sees their morning in the heroes' afternoon.



Morning — a hero at the counter, the rest of the party queuing behind.



Afternoon — a flask in flight at a pack of Emberlings.



Evening — the road, every hero's job and the pay, accounted for.

Character

Main character: Nell Ashgrove

A village witch who learned her craft at her grandmother's kitchen table — steady hands, a quick temper, and no business casting anything while angry. She never leaves the shop: the player *is* her, working the counter, the bench and the cauldron. We come to know her through her diary, written in the first person — guilty, stubborn and determined to put right what she thinks she broke.

Tam, her younger sibling, wanted to go somewhere she couldn't follow. Asleep at the table from the first night, Tam is the reason for everything; waking them is the goal of the whole game.



Nell Ashgrove



The Coven Matriarch

Antagonists: Sister Veil and the Coven Matriarch

Sister Veil calls at the counter from the first days, a customer like any other, and it is she who sends Nell after the cure. Her lines sharpen as Nell gets closer: *"You're asking questions about your grandmother. Don't. Ask about the cure."*

The **Matriarch** waits at the summit: six arms, a crown of spires, a ring of eyes and a cracked porcelain mask. Under the mask is **Grandmother Ysolde**, the Coven's prisoner and its weapon. The real enemy is the Coven itself, which is bigger than one Matriarch.

The heroes

Adventurers walk in as customers — each with a favourite element, a fee and a standard they hold the witch to — and she can hire them onto her roster. Once hired they come to the counter every morning to order the flask they will carry. On the road each is attuned to one element and has their own way of fighting, so choosing who carries which flask is half the game.

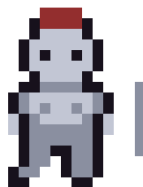


Rookie

your own adventurer

🔥 asks for Fire

"Whatever's in the flask is what I've got out there."



Ser Halden

wallguard captain

🔥 asks for Fire

"I need something that ends a fight faster than a spear does."



Mira Thorn

hedge-herbalist

🌿 asks for Nature

"Cut the leaf with the grain, mind. I'll know if you didn't."



Otho Vance

caravan factor

💧 asks for Water

"I don't buy potions. I buy outcomes."



Sister Veil

coven envoy

✨ asks for Arcane

"The Coven noticed your shop. That is not, in itself, good news."

Gameplay

Progression

The forest road runs through five regions, each themed on an element and each harder than the last. Earning at least one star on a region opens the next, and the witch can push into at most one new region a day — so the Coven's Peak is five days away at the very least, and most players will take many more. The first two roads can be held by one hero with nothing bought. From the third road on the waves are denser and tougher and bite harder, and a hero who walks it alone with nothing bought cannot hold it — the map says what tomorrow's road asks for.

#	Region	Element	What waits there	What it asks for
1	Whispering Woods	Nature	Bark Treants, Thornlings and a Water wave of Mossbacks; the Elder Woodwose, once it is cleared.	One hero, nothing bought
2	Cinder Peaks	Fire	Emberling packs and Cinder Hounds, the fastest creatures in the forest.	One hero, nothing bought
3	Frostbite Caverns	Water	Swarming Frostkin, Rimebeasts, an Arcane wave of Rime Wraiths and Frost Trolls.	Two heroes, the first road upgrades
4	Venom Swamp	Poison	Miremaws, Bog Treants, darting Mire Leeches, Bog Brutes and Blight Maws.	Three heroes, the first road upgrades
5	The Coven's Peak	Arcane	Coven Acolytes, Warded Effigies, Hexlings, Wardens — and the Coven Matriarch herself.	Three heroes, every road upgrade

Power grows in four ways, and the later roads are tuned so that a witch who skips them cannot pass:

- **Better brewing.** The recipe book grows as regions fall — quick two-step brews, balanced classics and five-step *deep* recipes that hit far harder but eat the morning clock.
- **More heroes.** Hiring is all it takes: a new hero (150, 240, 330, 420 gold) comes to the counter the next morning and orders their own flask, up to four on the road. Each levels from 1 to 5 (45, 80, 140, 240 gold), deliberately modestly: matching hero to flask matters more than grinding.
- **Road upgrades.** Heavier flasks, spare vials, thick boots and quick hands — then a second tier of tempered glass, a bandolier and hardened leathers.
- **Bench upgrades.** A clockwork stirrer, a draught kiln, a steeping vat, a drying rack, a brass mortar and a glass funnel. Each rebuilds its bench — it looks different the next morning — and several let a bench carry on alone, which is what makes a whole party's morning manageable.



Bought the night before: the iron pot turns copper under a clockwork paddle, the kiln is clad in copper with a heat dial, and herbs hang over a brass mortar.

Replayability

- Any cleared region can be replayed for half the fee but full loot — the way to farm gold and rare ingredients, and a safety net so the player can never get stuck.
- Every region is graded out of three stars, so there is always a cleaner run to chase.
- Each hero brings their own element and standards to the counter, visiting patrons back the Guild's commissions, and the three jobs on the board always pull in different directions.
- Fifteen hero perks (five elements × three fighting styles) and a choice of recipes make every party a different puzzle.

Game world

The game lives in two places. **The shop** is warm: candlelight flickering on shelves of stoppered jars, herbs hung up to dry and swinging in the draught, a cauldron bubbling in the middle of the room. **The forest** beyond the door is cold and elemental, and every region is drawn as a place of its own — its floor, its skyline and the air over it — with ground that matters: heroes slide on the Frostbite ice and wade slowly through the Venom Swamp's bog pools. The mood is cosy on the surface and uneasy underneath.

Everything is hand-made pixel art drawn from a single shared palette of around thirty colours, so the shop, the forest, the heroes and the interface all read as one world.



Herbs swirling in the cauldron mid-brew.

The shop

- **The Counter** — the heroes going out, one after another, three jobs on the board and a scouting report of every wave on today's road.
- **The Malting bench** — a steeping jar and a brick kiln: the grain is soaked, sprouted and dried before anything else.
- **The Prep bench** — leaves, roots and caps, each with an element, a potency and sometimes a wilt; the mortar and pestle.
- **The Cauldron** — the heart of the room, stirred by hand, or by a clockwork paddle once one is bought.
- **The Bottling table** — pour, seal and label.
- **The diary** — an open book on the witch's desk: a picture on the left page, her handwriting on the right.

The forest

- **The forest road** — the map of the five regions, the stars won on each and the choice of where to go tomorrow.
- **Whispering Woods** — a mossy clearing under a dark tree line, leaves falling.
- **Cinder Peaks** — basalt split by glowing lava, volcanoes on a red sky, embers rising.
- **Frostbite Caverns** — an ice floor under hanging icicles, snow drifting. Everyone slides.
- **Venom Swamp** — mud, reeds and toxic pools that drag at anyone who wades in.
- **The Coven's Peak** — flagstones round a rune circle at the foot of the spire.



The enraged Woodwose; its Thorn Volley's landing spots marked on the ground.

Gestalt

Alchemist's Arsenal feels like three small games in one day, and the contrast between them is the point. The **morning is a rush**: the clock is draining, one hero's grain is drying in the kiln while the next one's leaves wait in the mortar, the stir band is drifting and the player's hands are full. The **afternoon hands everything over**: the player sits back and watches the heroes use exactly what was made for them — a clean flask landing a double-damage hit, a sloppy one doing half as much, a hero running dry and pulling back. The **evening is quiet**: coins counted, a page of the diary turned, a decision about tomorrow. Frantic hands, calm mind, quiet evening.

What the player should feel

- **Ownership.** There is no abstract score. Every number the heroes deal traces back to something the player did that morning, and the game shows its working: the elemental wheel, the quality grades and even the heroes' reasoning are on screen, never hidden. Easy to read, deep to master.
- **Guilt turning into resolve — and then into forgiveness.** The story is told without walls of text: short animated cutscenes (a push-in, rain on the window, a charm flaring), one line at a time in each speaker's voice, and a diary whose eleven pages are the story's own pictures, one clue at a time. The tone is warm and a little melancholy, never grim.
- **A living place.** Every character speaks in a pitch-shifted, *Animalese*-style voice. The music is adaptive: a cosy shop theme crossfades into a tense forest theme the moment the heroes set off, and the story has its own — Grandmother's kettle-charm lullaby, which returns in a major key when Tam wakes. Not one of these is an audio file: every note, effect and voice is synthesised by the game as it plays.
- **Welcomed, not overwhelmed.** Day one is a guided tutorial: the clock drains slower, the stations open one at a time and an arrow points at the next thing to do. By day two the player is on their own.
- **Rising stakes.** Each region is harder than the last — from the third road on, nobody walks it alone and unequipped — the party grows, the mornings get more crowded, and the clues pile up, all building to the Coven's Peak and the mask.

Three moods, one day

	Morning	Afternoon	Evening
Hands	Full — racing the clock	Off — watching, reading	Resting — counting, choosing
Music	Cosy shop theme	Tense forest theme	Cosy shop theme
Colour	Candle gold, dark wood	The region's element	Parchment and ink
Question	"Can I make it well?"	"Did I make the right thing?"	"What do I do tomorrow?"



One flask for every element: Nature, Fire, Water, Poison and Arcane.

Gameplay mechanics

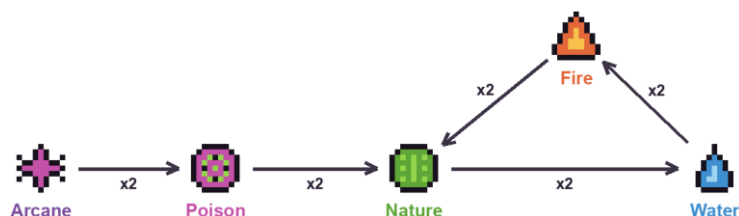


Core mechanics

- **Five physics benches, one flask per hero.** *Counter*: each hero going out picks one of three jobs — the safe standing order, a guild commission that pays far more but refuses a sloppy flask, or their own element, often the wrong one for the road. *Malting*: pour grain into the steep, where sound grain sinks and husks float to be skimmed, turn the sprouting bed, then dry it in the kiln, holding the heat in its band — good malt makes the herbs dissolve faster. *Prep*: toss the leaves into the mortar (they fly on real arcs), then press on the bowl to lift the pestle and let it drop: its speed at impact is the strike's grade. *Cauldron*: stir the way the recipe turns and hold the stir inside a drifting band — too slow and the brew catches and burns, too fast and it slops over the rim. *Bottling*: tip the ladle to pour real droplets to the line, cork it on the beat and label it. Each bench takes the next flask waiting for it, so a party's flasks are brewed side by side.
- **Quality from 0 to 100.** Every flask starts at 25 (Poor) and every action at every station pushes it up or down. The grade sets the fight:

Grade	Score	Damage	Pay	Elemental bonus	Flasks
Perfect	95–100	×1.20	×1.00 + tip	on	32
Great	80–94	×1.00	×1.00	on	28
Okay	60–79	×0.75	×0.70	on	24
Poor	below 60	×0.50	×0.40	off	20

- **The elemental wheel.** Every monster has an element, and bringing the right flask for the road doubles its damage:



Arrow = attacker deals x2 to defender. The reverse direction deals x0.5. Anything else x1.

- **Recipes.** Each element has several recipes of two to five steps that change the bomb itself — damage, blast radius, range and throw speed. Quick recipes save time; deep recipes hit harder. Potent herbs, and rare ones looted from the forest, push a flask further.
- **Heroes with perks.** Each hero deals +20% damage with a flask of their own element and takes 25% less from it, and fights as a *Skirmisher* (up close), *Marksman* (hangs back for the right target) or *Bulwark* (keeps throwing while hurt). Every perk is worth the same; what changes is where each hero shines. A hero who falls must rest the next day.
- **Heroes who think.** In the fight, heroes are not scripted: each one scores every possible throw — elemental match, distance, how many monsters the blast would catch, its own health — and commits to the best.
- **Physics everywhere.** Flasks and the guardians' volleys fly on true ballistic arcs; blasts and slams knock bodies back with falloff; heroes step out of a guardian's marked blows; the ice and the bog change how everyone moves; a fallen guardian comes apart into tumbling debris.

Enemies

The cursed forest is thick with elemental creatures, and every region's monsters share its element — which is exactly why the right flask matters. They arrive in waves the Counter scouts in advance, so the player always knows what is coming and has to decide what to brew for it. Most creatures walk straight at the heroes and bite on contact, harder the further up the road, and most regions mix in a wave of a different element that punishes a single-element plan — a party carrying more than one kind of flask does better.



Treantkin

Bark Treant · Thornling ·
Mossback · Bog Treant ·
Bog Brute

Nature / Water / Poison
34–630 HP

*Rooted and patient —
except the Thornlings;
the Brutes are the
heaviest things in the
swamp.*



Emberlings

Emberling · Cinder
Hound

Fire
40–55 HP

*Fire packs; the Cinder
Hound is the quickest
thing in the forest.*



Frostkin

Frostkin · Rimebeast ·
Rime Wraith · Frost Troll

Water / Arcane
105–390 HP

*Water swarms, Arcane
wraiths, and trolls that
soak up punishment.*



Miremaws

Miremaw · Mire Leech ·
Blight Maw

Poison
120–195 HP

*Poison bog-mouths that
hunt in packs; the
leeches dart.*



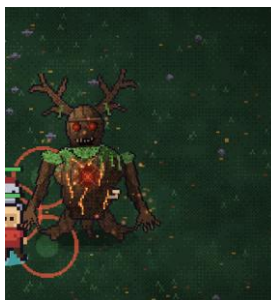
The Coven's own

Acolyte · Warded Effigy ·
Hexling · Warden

Arcane / Poison
70–300 HP

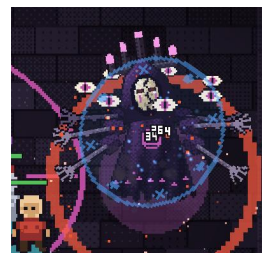
*Arcane servants; the
Wardens are the
toughest regular foes.*

Guardians

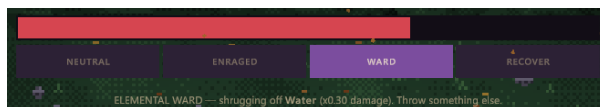


The Elder Woodwose

The **Elder Woodwose** (Nature) is an antlered giant of bark and moss with a heart-knot that beats like a coal; it waits at the end of the Whispering Woods once the road has been cleared. The **Coven Matriarch** (Arcane) floats at the summit. Every blow is **telegraphed**: the guardian winds up in a pose that matches the attack and marks each spot it will hit on the ground, and heroes step out of the marks. Guardians are not scripted: they weigh their health, the damage just taken and how hard one element is pressing, and shift between four phases shown on screen. The Woodwose shrinks to suit a small party; the Matriarch hardly does — the Peak is no place for one hero.



The Coven Matriarch



- **Neutral** — measured attacks, nothing resisted. **Enraged** — cracks and sigils burn, eyes go red, it moves faster and hits harder.
- **Elemental Ward** — hammer it with one element and a ring of runes wards it against exactly that one: the heroes must switch flasks. **Recovering** — it slumps and sheds pieces of itself: the window to finish it.

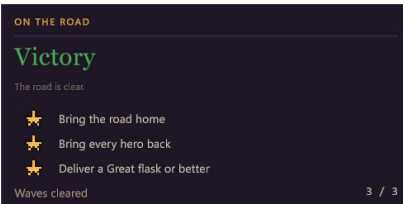
Attack	Guardian	Shape	Damage	Phase
Bramble Swipe	Woodwose	Strike on a marked spot	14	Neutral, Enraged
Thorn Volley	Woodwose	Five thorns, flat and fast	9 each	Neutral, Enraged
Root Slam	Woodwose	Shockwave around itself	20	Enraged
Hex Volley / Hex Storm	Matriarch	Three / seven lobbed hexes	11 / 9	Neutral, Ward / Enraged
Coven Slam	Matriarch	Strike on a marked spot	18	Neutral, Enraged
Sundering Ring	Matriarch	Wide shockwave	16	Enraged

Bonus

For players who want more than the road to the Coven’s Peak, the game rewards mastery and curiosity in ways that never lock the story away.

Three stars on every road

Every expedition is graded: one star for bringing the road home, one for bringing every hero back, and one for delivering a Great flask or better. Perfectionists will return to earlier regions with a stronger party and a steadier hand to fill in every star.



A three-star day in the Evening report

The diary

Eleven illustrated pages unlock as the story moves — the first night, a clue from each region cleared, the first Perfect potion, the Woodwose’s last words, and the ending — and a note slides in whenever one does. Read in order, the pages are enough to guess the twist before the Peak says it aloud.

Rare ingredients

Monsters sometimes drop rare herbs — **Emberleaf**, **Frostmoss**, **Cinder Heart**, **Venom Sac** and the **Coven Sigil**. Carried home, they appear on the prep bench as ingredients stronger than anything the witch can buy, feeding the forest’s spoils straight back into the next morning’s brew.



Herbs of every element — rare ones brew stronger flasks.

Rare herb	Dropped by	Where	Chance
Emberleaf	Bark Treant	Whispering Woods	40%
Frostmoss	Mossback, Frostkin	Whispering Woods, Frostbite Caverns	30–35%
Cinder Heart	Emberling	Cinder Peaks	15%
Venom Sac	Miremaw	Venom Swamp	40%
Coven Sigil	Warded Effigy	The Coven’s Peak	50%

A complete roster

Collect a hero for every element — five heroes, fifteen possible perks — and raise them all to level five.

Perfect flasks and the Guild

A Perfect potion earns a tip on top of the fee. The Guild commission pays far more for a Great flask and halves the pay if the witch falls short — the high-stakes job for confident brewers, and a reason to keep sharpening every station long after the story is done.

Money

Alchemist's Arsenal will be released **free on itch.io** as a complete game — no ads, no microtransactions and nothing locked behind a payment. Every region, hero, recipe and page of the story is unlocked by playing.

Players who enjoy it can leave an optional **pay-what-you-want tip** on the itch.io page. Tips support further development and never unlock anything in-game: a player who pays nothing gets exactly the same game as one who pays.

Distribution

- A Windows **installer** (built with Inno Setup) and a portable zip, both hosted on the itch.io page.
- Updates delivered through itch.io and the itch desktop app, so existing players are kept up to date automatically.
- Saves are stored locally and survive updates.

Future content

Free updates may add new regions, heroes, recipes and chapters of the diary. The ending deliberately leaves room for more: the Coven is bigger than one Matriarch, and Sister Veil will be back.

Why free

As an independent first release, the aim is players and feedback rather than revenue. A free game on itch.io reaches the widest audience, invites honest reviews and builds an audience for whatever comes next — and keeping the game free of pay-to-win mechanics keeps the focus where it belongs: on skill at the bench and good judgement about who to send down the road.